Brown in cultures and traditions

Brown is a colour people long thought of as "ordinary". Soil, wood, bread. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about craft, faith and trade than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how brown is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Brown in different cultures

Mali

In Mali a cloth called bogolan is made, sometimes called mud cloth. In the Bambara language the word joins earth or mud and cloth. Men weave narrow strips of cotton, women soak them in a bath of n'gallama tree leaves until they turn yellow. Then they paint patterns on them with a brush or a stick using fermented river mud. **The iron in the mud reacts with the dye** and the pattern stays dark even after washing.

From a craft where colour is truly born from the earth and human work. Around 1980 bogolan began to establish itself as a symbol of Malian identity.

Brown here is not just a shade. It is **a joining of place, material and meaning**.

Australia

Aboriginal Australians have used ochre for tens of thousands of years. According to an overview on Wikipedia, ochre painting has been widespread for more than forty thousand years. It serves for body decoration, ceremonies, painting in caves and on bark, protecting the skin and in healing. Ochre was traded across the continent along so-called songlines and over four hundred pits are known.

From a tradition where colour has its purpose and its owner. Ochre patterns are, according to descriptions, the cultural property of a specific clan and the shades have their own meanings.

A colour can be **the memory of the land**. It is not suited to being made a decoration without a story.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Italy

In **1525** a reform of the Franciscans began in Italy, led by Matteo da Bascio. From it the Capuchin order arose. They wear a simple brown tunic with a large pointed hood, in Italian cappuccio. The name of the order comes from this hood.

From religious life, where the colour means simplicity. Coffee with a little milk began to be called cappuccino after the colour of the Capuchin habits. In Vienna a similar "Kapuziner" may have been served as early as the eighteenth century.

Brown here carries a vow of poverty. And today we drink it as morning coffee.

Mexico

In Mexico and the region people drank cocoa long before Europeans arrived. The Mokaya people in Chiapas drank bitter frothy cocoa drinks as early as around **1900 BCE**. For the Maya the oldest evidence dates to around 600 BCE and before 400 BCE cocoa beans were used as currency. The Aztecs collected them from conquered peoples as tribute.

From ceremonies and trade, where brown had the value of a coin. Cocoa reached Spain in the mid-sixteenth century and the first documented official shipment to Europe is from 1585.

Brown here is not just a taste. It is **a colour of value** that people sent to one another.

Brown in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at brown **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Traditional Chinese medicine

In the classical system of five elements earth is linked mainly with yellow. Brown comes close to it in extended interpretations through soil and earthy shades. **It has no organ circuit of its own.** In the traditional system earth includes the spleen, stomach, nourishment and also worry or rumination. The organ names denote broader traditional functional connections.

How it relates to brown. For our work with colour the interesting theme is what I take in, what I give out and whether I forget myself in the process. Earth in this picture is **what nourishes and holds you**.

And what if I asked you now?

"What really nourishes me, and what only takes from me?"

Everyone has enough. And you?

You eat on your own standing up. You put off rest because it is not finished yet. In the evening you no longer want to choose anything, not even what would please you. But you are in that household too. In earth symbolism you can stop at care that should include you, not just as another task of being a more perfect carer.

How to involve brown

If it is pleasant to you, give it a place where you truly receive something for yourself. On a wooden table clear a space to eat. Take your favourite ceramic bowl and sit down instead of finishing lunch on the way between two tasks. **The benefit comes from the whole moment.** The colour alone does not replace nutrition or care for health.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to brown. Ayurveda works with qualities such as warmth and cold, lightness and heaviness, movement and stability. Brown on a soft blanket can recall warmth and rest, on heavy furniture in a dark room heaviness. **No rule arises** from this such as "vata needs brown and kapha must not have it".

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. A muted brown and beige can feel cooling and calming. A sharp rust and brick may pour oil on the fire.

- **Beige and linen**
  Calming and light, as a base.
- **Beware of rust**
  A hot and rich brown can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. The traditional approach stresses regularity and calming changeability. Brown on a blanket and in natural materials can add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Caramel and honey**
  Warm and earthy, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft textiles and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. When heaviness and immobility predominate, the tradition advises stimuli to activity. Dark brown areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a light and lively companion**.

- **Light wood and green**
  A fresh counterweight.
- **Add movement**
  Orange or yellow as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.

After a chaotic day a cosy corner can be a relief. After long days without movement and interest you may feel like opening a window, adding light and going out. A useful question is whether your surroundings offer you just what you lack now.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe brown as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement.

How it relates to brown. Soil, clay and roots belong to the images of earth that in the shared human imagination are often linked with motherhood and fertility. You can take brown as the colour of **what carries and nourishes us**. When you think about it, ask where support comes to you from and whether you accept it.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same brown can be a home for one woman and a cage for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In some approaches earthy browns are linked with earth and stability. With wooden objects the material itself and the element of wood also enter the interpretation. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

Brown is like tree bark

A little gives a space firmness, a whole trunk turns it into a cave. Being settled is not the number of brown things.

Simple tips

- **Start with a question**
  Do I feel settled here, or swamped? The difference is often in the light and in whether each thing has a reason to be here.
- **Give wood the main role**
  Wood can remain the main character. It does not have to play all the supporting roles at the same time.
- **Vary the surfaces**
  Wood, leather, linen and ceramics work together better than five equally smooth surfaces.
- **Add light**
  A lamp by the armchair, a window without heavy curtains. Lighter textiles brighten the whole.
- **Watch the undertones**
  Reddish wood, a yellow-brown floor and a cool grey-brown sofa can "clash energetically".
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it both in the morning and in the evening.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH Brown is boring.

TRUTH Brown is the colour of earth, wood, coffee and leather. In a flat it adds warmth, in clothing calm. It is boring only when it is everywhere in the same way.

MYTH Brown belongs only to autumn.

TRUTH Milky shades, caramel or cappuccino work all year round. Spring brown is simply lighter.

MYTH Brown and black must not be combined.

TRUTH An older fashion rule claimed it, today it is taken more loosely. Watch the contrast and the material. Brown with black can be very elegant.

What brown goes well with

- **Cream and linen**
  A lighter, softer impression.
- **Green**
  An image of nature and growth.
- **Blue and turquoise**
  A cooler contrast to a warm base.
- **Pink**
  A softness that changes a settled impression.
- **Orange and rust**
  Warmth. Make sure the whole is not too dense.
- **Black and white**
  Black is depth with a risk of merging, white adds separation of the individual parts.

Elements

- **Earth**
  Brown is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and orange warm it up.
- **Metal**
  White and light metal lighten it and set it apart.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A brown sofa can be a pleasant base. Wood adds grain, a leather armchair another surface, a linen cushion lightness.

What to watch for. When the sofa, floor, curtains and cupboards are all similarly dark, the individual parts blend.

A simple tip. Try a lighter textile, a cream surface, a green plant or a blue detail.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Wood, brown ceramics and earthy shades connect to bread, coffee and everyday dining.

What to watch for. A small kitchen full of dark cupboards. A cosy kitchen is pleasant, looking for an onion in colour-unified gloom less so.

A simple tip. Add worktop lighting and a lighter companion.

Bedroom

What works. Chocolate bedding, pleasant wood and soft light create a place you look forward to. Brown can be bodily, warm and sensual.

What to watch for. When the bed, wardrobe, throw, curtains and carpet are all brown, you may perceive heaviness instead of cosiness. More as an image of a feeling than a feng shui rule you may then experience it as a "break-up colour". Brown does not cause a break-up, it can only be part of a surrounding that recalls stagnation.

A simple tip. Swap a large dark throw for a cream or light sandy one and let daylight into the room. If the feeling of emptiness stays, that is information too. Perhaps the relationship needs attention now, not another cushion.

Children's room

What works. Brown wood can form a pleasant base. But leave room also for colours, pictures and the child's choice.

What to watch for. A forest room does not have to be only trunks. It also has leaves, light and perhaps a purple dinosaur, if it has just moved in with the child.

A simple tip. Leave room for other colours and for a change of taste.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Study

What works. A wooden desk can be beautiful and practical, it adds a firm base.

What to watch for. A whole room that recalls a study you went into to knock and rather object to nothing.

A simple tip. A lighter main view, fewer things and a colour that pleases you.

Hallway and bathroom

What works. Brown tiles or wood can feel warm and lived-in.

What to watch for. In a room without a window, watch how much light remains. A dark floor, walls and furniture turn a cosy impression into a cave.

A simple tip. A lighter surface, suitable lighting and fewer visually heavy things.

And try answering now

“Why do I want brown at home? What should it bring me, cosiness, a firm home base, or a wish to move again here?”

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.